

The Next Time

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The next time we

go stumbling through

bright woods

in search of darkness,

the next time we

hold our breath

and shear our

paper wings off,

the next time we trust

the tower guard

with the unblinking eye,

the next time

we believe anything

taught in a world so

fraught it's impossible

to emerge from;

the next time we brave

this wilderness

with innocence,

unquestioning belief

in the pure motives

of our narrative,

the next time

we mistake our

stumble for our

arrival, the next rescue

will be ours:

in the tears that bind us

to kindness

we'll flounder in

the big bright darkness,

our bright eyes

shining wet

and full of stars.

<end poem 1>

Rumination

(It's like scratching an itch
to go down into that darkness).

A prying scratch, prising the light from your eyes, dimming your grin, cracking your teeth,
weathering them to old porcelain.

Some ancient addiction, perhaps,
a rage at being born, at the windmilling
futility of it all.

It's easy to do, too,
because pain we may presume a greater gift than joy
against the ravages of time and space
as it's less fleeting;

love might be the point, but
like a precious gem it's mined near through
and the marketplace is flooded with fakes.

And the ones who hate—
the ones who spend their every waking
moment burning to lash out at any who scrape
the barest happiness out of this circumstance
in order to remind them all the time
how very miserable they really
must be at the mess we've made
of our whole family tree—
well they make life memorable, too.

(Yes, it gets easy after a while
scratching the itch
that pulls us down, down, beneath the skin).

<end poem 2>

You Get to an Age

When you think nothing human
can surprise. That's why I unblocked you, the dead rapist;
such magnanimity, such largesse
of spirit, it swells my chest, presses
against my lungs, flattening speech, flattening breath,
choking me to death, along with those awful
tears that morning I discovered you'd died,
just months after I told you I longed to see you
swinging at the end of your rope.

I'm here because you can still surprise.
Not your political takes, whether those I disagree with,
on the basis of my own humanity (the rhetorical lens
through which you viewed life was misogyny),
or those I agree with, because I am also a struggling teacher,
a struggling writer, just
struggling, saddled with the same
impostor syndrome that you had,
only mine's more learned than earned--
one of the many problems you had with me,
wasn't it? (I was a better version of you
in your mind, and to make matters worse, a woman).

But no. What surprised me is how you managed
to piss me off from beyond the grave.
You were homeless before you died;
even your family didn't have the heart anymore
to help you. --What can I say? What drove them away?
In the end, was it your alcoholism, which really was just your medicine
to forget who you were, for even a second?
Something like that--something that caused *them* trouble--
something so visibly out of place in the carefully-curated
museum to middle-class values that was their ranch-style home:
I could imagine *that* finally doing the trick.

Not all the women raped, stalked, strangled in the world
would be enough to make your mother stop smothering
you with her suffocating bond, but you getting too
drunk at family dinner;
well, that's another matter altogether.

What pissed me off is the way you talked
of your life. "As a homeless man with PTSD..."
I suppose van der Kolk, when tallying up the score, spoke
in his book with some sympathy about men like you,
such as the man who couldn't stop shaking after he raped and murdered
a woman during wartime.
Poor guy, I couldn't help but think,
haunted by her ghost, crying out night after night *why did you do it*.
Maybe some wounds we should have to live with.

When I was nineteen, my childhood friend and I
got high with a pair of drug dealers.
I was getting over a relationship with another abuser
of women, this one who liked to strangle, punch, use the same words
his father had used for him when he did the same,
useless, what's the point of you.
I was working full-time after leaving him,
finishing up my degree; he found himself adrift after all the harm
without family to help, a lot like you.
My friend was struggling with addiction, a disease;
I did not know, nor did I know
why we were at that house, just that it started with weed
and progressed to coke, line after line,
and a fight broke out, about, of all things, rape,
which I'd already experienced but couldn't bring myself
to admit, not even to myself.
I played Devil's advocate, arguing I'd rather
be raped than rapist, that even if he
killed you a rapist couldn't touch your soul,
but with that one moment he shattered his own.

They grew angry, telling me, as they gave my friend,
who later almost died, line after line
of the drug that was killing her, that such criminals
should be rounded up, released on an island,
with only each other for company;
I argued that the soul of a rapist is destroyed by his act
worse than he could ever hurt his victim.
They showed us out then, *no harm, no foul*.
Angry faces, fist bump at the door.
I still remember.

I've had plenty of personal chances to reevaluate;
yet the only thing I got wrong was how much of my soul
a man like you could take.
Each injection of venom and each attempt to evade it
left me injured, fragmented, strewn across a psychic landscape
more hostile than anyplace on Earth; the war to end
all wars, every bit of evil man can commit, lives in that land,
and the soul, finding itself stranded, flees to whatever foxhole
it can find, sometimes never to be seen again.
I get back fragments, since then; but rapacious, stubborn,
I won't give in. I'm in search of it all, and more;
I want to get something out of this in the end;
or what was it all for, my friend?

When I discovered you died
I cried, because I loved you,
in the beginning. I used to imagine us living in a little house
across from downtown campus, teaching together,
in the early days we knew each other.
All the abstract understanding--of your envy, your insecurity, your personality
disorder, your mental health struggles, your childhood--
will never make me understand
why you set out to destroy someone who loved you;
(or why you weren't the first man nor the last).
It's as if love is some sort of affront,

some violent act, one which deserves a response in kind.

Who knows. Maybe you did get PTSD
from raping, from stalking, from systematically breaking
me down, watching me cry
in your arms, knowing I *hated* you,
that even up to the day you reached out from the shelter,
all I wanted was you dead.

When I heard you died, I laughed like a maniac.
I laughed all goddamn day and night.
I may be sick as a dog, but here I am, and I'm alive;
10 years later, and which one of us made it?
--Every act shriveled you, didn't it?
You looked like a wizened old man when you died.
Let me go back in time and tell those two young dealers that.
In the end what you take from others you can't get back.

<end poem 3>

Raison d'Etre

If there was any reason in at all,
all the violence I've experienced,
if somewhere there is a logic
to the universe,
from atom to Adam,
then it is this, in the end,
not rock bottom
but resurrection.

What's clear is the numbness
I've carried since childhood—a shield
against suffering—can happen
to anyone. And it does,
eventually, too, to nearly
everyone, just to some
very slowly what it did to me all at once, same

fading, same dissolution,
but at different speeds—nearly
everyone ends up a ghost.

Whether violence
or the drip-drip-drip erosion
of nothing much happening
it doesn't matter which kills us;
in an age of iterative screens,
a shrine to dissociation in every bedroom
ghosts argue with ghosts
(the spirit of an angry God's
bad joke—we declare Him dead so He decides
to curse such ingrates by engineering lives
so bereft we forget
every second is precious).

In this age, shrieks feel more alive
than sighs; sometimes the hull must breach
for us to sense it, and if there's a reason
I had to repeat
the many violations of my youth
in my thirties, only worse—(make it
more devastating this time,
someone must have chimed in,
some shiftless staff
writer, armchair director)—
—in hindsight, this was it, wasn't it?

—All this was the gift.—

—They've given me many,
my cleverest hunters,
the men who laid careful traps
as if I were a rare deer,
a delicacy necessary
for the men's survival,
as if my cries ringing out

above birds and brook were not
in fact the downstream consequence
of such men's creature comforts;
—I thank those clever hunters,
who gave so much of themselves
to the hunt,
and I thank too what architects
must exist, for their gifts:
a hard-won insight
into how the light dies in others' eyes,
the first time that it went out
in mine.

—But of all their magnificent gifts—the joy
in suffering, the pained burden
of violence—the price of sickness
remains greatest;
because the only way out of a gray plane
of existence—that place of dead space
and pain, of static
interspliced with blood, of towers
of ever-teetering tasks,
of screams that bury us
where we expected paradise,
the only way out, back to the sunlit
patch of promise into which
we were born, is
to nearly die, to be resurrected, to become
that being of light born of one's own ashes;
—but before all that to be

simply Lazarus, to sink
to the floor to kiss it, on our
knees to shake
with laughter, and so to exit
the cold cave of
our embodiment, blind;

—all the old shapes,
those cave shadows, vanish
in one sun-struck blink
of a bleary eye; and
tears fallen, the light
streams in, as we rush to greet
our enemies with a kiss
and then our friends.
<end poem 4>